

Ankle Fracture

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Provenance note: This PDF is a local English-text snapshot of the official page. Navigation was removed.
The medical text below was not translated, paraphrased, or supplemented.

Ankle Fracture

Patient information leaflet describing what a fracture is, the symptoms and what to do while recovering from it.

Information for patients This leaflet can be made available in other formats including large print, CD and Braille and in languages other than English, upon request.

What is fracture?

A fracture is a break in the bone that happens when more force is applied to the bone than it can take. Ankle fractures usually involve the fibula, the smaller of the two bones in your lower leg.

The break can happen below, at or above the ankle joint. There are times when the larger bone of the lower leg, the tibia, can also be affected.

What are the symptoms of an ankle fracture?

There are a variety of symptoms that you may experience with an ankle fracture. The most common symptoms are often swelling, bruising, tenderness, difficulty or pain when walking or putting weight through the ankle.

What are the potential complications?

After an ankle fracture, it is crucial to be aware of complications like Deep Vein Thrombosis (DVT) and Complex Regional Pain Syndrome (CRPS). If you are getting throbbing pain, swelling, changes in skin colour and increased warmth of the area, please seek medical attention.

What can I do to aid my recovery?

It is important to follow the advice you have been given by the hospital or fracture clinic.

Take painkillers recommended by your doctor to help ease the pain.

Try and engage in early movement exercises guided by doctors and physiotherapists.

Gently move your toes and bend your knee while wearing your boot or cast to ease muscle stiffness.

Factors such as:

Stopping smoking.

Controlling alcohol intake.

Management of diabetes play a significant role in effective healing.

These factors increase inflammation in our bodies, which unfortunately reduces our ability to undergo effective healing.

For further advice, please see useful links section.

What exercises can I do to help my recovery?

When recovering from ankle fractures, a proper exercise routine is vital. A slight increase in discomfort and possible swelling during exercises is expected initially, but this should settle within 24 hours. It may benefit you to take your painkillers before doing your exercises to allow you to do this comfortably. If the pain continues or becomes unmanageable, you may need to consider an adjustment to your activity level. Try and aim to complete the exercises regularly throughout the day.

Exercises:

Ankle Pumps

Pull your toes, foot up towards you, and point your foot down as away from you as you can. Complete 3 sets of 15 repetitions.

Ankle Circles:

Without moving your knee, move your foot and toes towards the inside (towards the other foot). Return and repeat. Complete 3 sets of 15 repetitions.

Frequently asked questions

Why does my ankle look a funny shape?

As a fracture heals, new bone is formed at the site of the break in the bone (callus). This can result in a lump forming on the side of your ankle. This is normal and your ankle may change shape again over 12 to 18 months as the bone remodels itself.

What is a moon boot and how long should I wear it for?

A moon boot is a device that helps to keep your ankle and foot in a fixed position to help with healing, and avoid further injury. The moon boot should normally be used for the first 6 weeks after your injury, when you stand and walk. Some people may need to use the boot for longer, depending on their injury. Your boot can be removed when you rest your ankle or do your exercises.

When can I start driving?

When you have a good movement and strength to be able to control the pedals. You must be able to perform an emergency stop safely and pain free.

This will vary between individuals but is usually six to eight weeks after removal of the plaster. You may wish to seek guidance from your insurance company and physiotherapist.

How will I know when to stop using my crutches?

Crutches are provided to help early mobilisation and gradually increase weight bearing through the foot and ankle. Over time, you should slowly increase the amount of weight you put through your foot as pain allows under guidance of a physiotherapist.

Useful Contacts

Universal Hospital of North Tees

Orthopaedic Outpatients

Telephone: 01642 624 486

University Hospital of Hartlepool

Orthopaedic Outpatients

Telephone: 01429 522 590

Physiotherapy Appointment Queries

Telephone: 01429 522 471

Monday to Friday, 09:00 a.m. to 04:30 p.m.

Other Useful Links

• **Make Every Contact Count Gateway – MECC –**
<https://www.meccgateway.co.uk/nenc>

• NHS Live Well – Healthy Weight – Advice and education on weight loss and maintain a healthy weight –
<https://www.nhs.uk/live-well/healthy-weight>

Comments, concerns, compliments or complaints

Patient Experience Team (PET)

We are continually trying to improve the services we provide. We want to know what we're doing well or if there's anything which we can improve, that's why the Patient Experience Team (PET) is here to help. Our Team is here to try to resolve your concerns. The office is based at the University Hospital of North Tees if you wish to discuss concerns in person. Our contact details are:

Telephone: 01642 624719 Freephone: 0800 092 0084 Opening hours: Monday to Friday, 9:30am to 4:00pm Email:

Out of hours

Out of hours if you wish to speak to a senior member of Trust staff, please contact the hospital switchboard who will bleep the appropriate person. Telephone: 01642 617617

Patient, Public and People with Lived Experience

We are looking for patients to share their experiences of healthcare and to join our Involvement Bank. Working with the patients, carers, families and the general population we support in making decisions about their care can lead to better health outcomes, increased patient satisfaction and a better overall experience. We want to listen and work with you in shaping the future of your healthcare services. To find out more about the Involvement Bank go to our website or contact us at:

Website:

www.nth.nhs.uk/about/community/people-with-lived-experience Email:

Data protection and use of patient information

The Trust has developed Data Protection policies in accordance with Data Protection Legislation (UK General Data Protection Regulations and Data Protection Act 2018) and the Freedom of Information Act 2000. All of our staff respect these policies and confidentiality is adhered to at all times. If you require further information on how we process your information please see our Privacy Notices.

Telephone: 01642 383551

Email:

Leaflet feedback

This leaflet has been produced in partnership with patients and carers. All patient leaflets are regularly reviewed, and any suggestions you have as to how it may be improved are extremely valuable. Please write to the Clinical Governance team at:

Email:

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